



ACCESSIBLE PEDAGOGY WORKSHOP III

Designing Engagement: Centering Care

“If disability is something we avoid talking about in the push for ‘wellness’ on campus, in creating euphemistic names like ‘Access Services’ or ‘AccessAbility’ instead of disability offices, and if disability is only ever mentioned as something researchers are ‘fighting,’ this will undoubtedly impact and negatively shape the environment for disabled students.”

-Jay Dolmage¹

Stop believing students all learn one way. Stop thinking that they will learn the way you do. (dolmage)

Higher education employs logics of both **ableism** and **disableism**

Disablism: “a set of assumptions (conscious or unconscious) and practices that promote the differential or unequal treatment of people because of actual or presumed disabilities” (Kumari Campbell, 4)

>> it says that there could be nothing worse than being disabled

Ableism: values able-bodiedness and able-mindedness, thus constructing disability as a negative

Disablism can never be fully disconnected from ableism

“academia powerfully mandates able-bodiedness and able-mindedness, as well as other forms of social and communicative hyperability, and this demand can best be defined as ableism”

Multiple Means of Engagement

Multiple means of engagement refer to the “why” of learning. It focuses on the reasons students choose to take a course, what piques their interest, and how they stay motivated over time. There are three concepts related to engagement in UDL:

- Provide options for **recruiting interest**: Optimize individual choice and autonomy; Optimize relevance, value, and authenticity; Minimize threats and distractions.

¹ Jay Timothy Dolmage, *Academic Ableism: Disability and Higher Education* (University of Michigan Press, 2017), 124.

- Provide options for **sustaining effort** and **persistence**: Heighten salience of goals and objectives; Vary demands and resources to optimize challenge; Foster collaboration and community; Increase mastery-oriented feedback.
- Provide options for **self-regulation**: Promote expectations and beliefs that optimize motivation; Facilitate personal coping skills and strategies; Develop self-assessment and reflection.

Multiple Means of Representation

Multiple means of representation refer to the “what” of learning. Here we are talking about the content of the course and the ways that that content is delivered to the student. These include your lecture, a slide deck, a textbook or other readings, video or audio recordings, visual representations, models, or any number of other interesting and creative ways to demonstrate the important concepts of the material. There are three key considerations related to representation in UDL:

- Provide options for **perception**: Offer ways of customizing the display of information; Offer alternatives for auditory information; Offer alternatives for visual information.
- Provide options for **language & symbols**: Clarify vocabulary and symbols; Clarify syntax and structure; Support decoding of text, mathematical notation, and symbols; Promote understanding across languages; Illustrate through multiple media.
- Provide options for **comprehension**: Activate or supply background knowledge; Highlight patterns, critical features, big ideas, and relationships; Guide information processing and visualization; Maximize transfer and generalization.

Multiple Means of Action and Expression

Multiple means of action and expression refer to the “how” of learning. This is where we consider how our students will interact with the content of the course. Forms of action and expression range from completing practice questions to participating in class discussions, group work, assignments, and tests. The three key concepts of action and expression are:

- Provide options for **physical action**: Vary the methods for response and navigation; Optimize access to tools and assistive technologies
- Provide options for **expression & communication**: Use multiple media for communication; Use multiple tools for construction and composition; Build fluencies with graduated levels of support for practice and performance
- Provide options for **executive functions**: Guide appropriate goal-setting; Support planning and strategy development; Facilitate managing information and resources; Enhance capacity for monitoring progress

Deep Accessibility (Star Ford): extending from physical disability to sensory and cognitive levels of accessibility through five levels:

1. Movement—*getting there*—how we get to an event or class
2. Sense—*being there*—how we access the material, the conversation
3. Architecture—*orienting*—how the space and layout structure our belonging and understanding
4. Communication—how we join the conversation, engage, understand, and are understood
5. Agency—*autonomy*—how we can come to have a shaping role in the event or class, as well as the right to define our own identity and involvement

Dolmage's explication of deep accessibility demonstrates that we must think deeply about our pedagogical praxis and grasp at the root of certain teaching practices and structures in order to open them up and render them accessible. This framework builds upon Universal Design for Learning (UDL), a framework that rewrites universal design principles into pedagogical practices and similarly writes against the retrofit model of accessibility. By rethinking our pedagogical practices to center access, we create more equitable classroom communities in which all members are able to participate and shape their learning, from instructor to student. Critically, deep accessibility lightens the burden on the instructor to retrofit existing policies and practices and shifts the focus to allow students and instructors alike to collaboratively build a shared classroom space.

Three major moves of UDL mandates:

1. Multiple means of student engagement (why students learn) – tap in learners' interests, offer appropriate challenges, and increase motivation
2. Multiple means of delivering content (what students learn) – to give learners various ways of acquiring information and knowledge
3. Multiple ways for students to express themselves and act (how students learn) – to provide learners alternatives for demonstrating what they know